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The Nature of Life

The little town I lived in, Sutton, has a small elementary school, a small library, a small post office, a small historic park, and a small general store, but a vast expanse of wilderness. In the summer, we are surrounded by lush green mountains that either shield us from powerful winds or trap them in, depending on the directions of the gust. The houses in town are well-spaced, many were three to four acres apart. Our property consists of 25 acres and is populated by spruce, birch, and cottonwood trees. There's also a small creek that ran along our property; the Artic Chars were most abundant there. Almost all creeks in Alaska had fresh, often very cold, clear water, so most people enjoy just looking at them. But I dive in it.

In my parent's lifetime, nurturing ten children was their greatest achievement, so they say. They weren't scholars, educators, or even formally educated; my folks were farmers, just like many of the Hmong people. The Hmong seemed to be attracted to mountains, as that's where many of my people were located. We live there, thrive, and call it home. Maybe it's the possibility of becoming a home that we choose to think of it that way. I guess it's the indigenous magnet rooted in our DNA that made my parents decide Alaska to be our home. The last frontier, Alaska, is what made me who I am today, a loyal, focused, and stubborn son.

It was in rural Alaska that my parents started to tap into their farming skills they've carried from Laos. You see, my parents and the family lived in Michigan where we lived as first-generation immigrants after the notorious Vietnam War. My father would tell us stories of how peaceful life was before the war. Villages of just our people and harmony within each of them. My parents' garden was what usually came up in the middle of every story. Father would tell us

that their rice fields were so big, it took weeks of hard work just to harvest parts of the field. That's why the collaboration of villagers and close family members was so vital. As the war began its destruction, change soon circulated the mountains. People gradually started to flee from villages, saying that they were going to tend to their gardens, trying not to arouse any suspicions.

In the jungle of Laos, trying to survive was the main objective. There's just so many ways to end people's lives, especially in a humid jungle where people were prone to sickness and starvation. If that wasn't enough, mines hidden on trails set by guerilla soldiers, poisoning of water sources, and the most popular, guns. During that time while trying to reach the refugee camp in Thailand, two of my older brothers died from starvation or some sickness, no one knew entirely. With the living on the line, not even a proper burial was given. When my parents finally reached the refugee camp, they told us it was like an overcrowded cage that would even be unfit for livestock to live in. After they were out of the camp, life became better, but it was hard and expensive for a big family because they soon had my elder sister and six older brothers. When the chance to come to America was possible, my father hesitated but took it anyways.

We moved from Michigan to Alaska, the first two years of attending to Sutton's elementary school was easy going, only because I could communicate with my older brothers. But soon after they left for middle school, which was 15 miles away, I was left alone. I was in fourth grade, but still had poor English literacy, so making friends became a burden, at times I didn't even try. Even though I didn't have any childhood friends, I didn't feel bad or felt like I needed any. The kids I was surrounded by later grew up to be smokers, drinkers, or substance abusers, so I'm thankful for not seeing eye to eye with them.

After school was out, all I would think about was going outside, playing sports, or building dams with rocks at the creek. I'd spend most of my summer in the cool, rushing water.

Dragging, pushing, and pinning all rocks in the vicinity. My first time making the dam was a disaster. I had no idea, technique, or any skills I could use to apply to building any dams. I had no clue what I was trying to achieve. Rocks would tumble along by the strength of the stream, and that repetitive action was enough to make me stop constructing. What I've noticed, is that even as a child, cooling down to think rationally was easy for me and it became easier when I surrounded myself in the pleasant aura of nature. A sense of peace was always there for me, whether or not I needed it.

I always had the luxury of venturing into the wilderness. It was the unknown that intrigued me. Here, expectations did not exist. Here in the wild, I become as neutral as the environment, where no one controls me as I control nothing. Moving along the paths made by the repetitive use of the trail, by the animals and me, I carried my fishing rod, trying to get out of any tangles along the way. The only thought in my mind was the acoustic surrounding. I felt as if every move I made was heard by the entire forest and its' creatures. The beautiful sound of birds chirping sounded like an invitation, the wind rustling the leaves pushing me deeper, and the stream calling out to me. When I arrived at my destination, I slid down a steep ledge to access the creek, where I then explored the stream with my rod and reel. The zing of my reel was music to my ears. The fish flung, flicked, and flopped its body as it entered back into its element. I waded down the creek and my eyes caught a glimpse of natural pools of slow moving water. Logs jammed against one another, clogged with twigs and mushy leaves. This structure may have always been here, but I guess I've never given it full respect, because I never needed it. I'd be blind now if I didn't recognize that this is a perfect structure. I imitated this design, except for logs I used large rocks for the foundation.

I returned to my undisturbed and unfinished dam. There were no big rocks that were fully out of the dirt. I scanned around and set my curious eyes on a mossy green rock. I had a choice; I could run back to the shed and grab a spade shovel to dig up the stone or use my hands and the abundant sticks around me. Of course, I thought about it, but I offered my hands instead because I wanted a challenge. I dug into the dirt that cemented the rock and clawed the mud off. Pushing and pulling, I finally was able to set it free. The rock was like a submerged iceberg, devious to the eyes and much larger than I thought. It only showed a little above the surface, but it's true mass was underneath the earth. However, it sure made a great start to the foundation of my dam. I repeated this procedure until there were no bigger rocks. That meant I had to go either up or downstream to gather more. I decided to try both. Rolling the boulders, half the size of myself, with the current was much easier than going against it, but I found out that by going against the current I was able to maneuver it better, because it didn't go with the flow, it went wherever I wanted it to go.

As I started to work my ways towards the end of my dam, I noticed that the water has been rising and the force of this side of the dam was tremendous compared to the normal current of the stream. What I have done was magnified the speed of the creek by letting this pool of water rushing out only one way. My answer to this was quite simple, I needed bigger rocks. I stacked rocks over rocks, but no matter how big they were, each one was swept away. I finally said okay, I'll let there be an outlet from this dam. I told myself, this would be a great way for the fishes like chars, trout, or salmon to swim upstream. The truth was, there was no way for me to carry large enough rocks to plug that final part of the dam. But I still accepted this lie.

The problem with creeks fed from mountain tops is that when it rains, the water accumulates and pools in from every part of the mountain like a funnel, and thus the water could

rise significantly. I remembered when we had a big rainstorm, the smooth streaming creek I once knew now became a raging river. I have never seen it so murky and fast. The thought of diving into a creek like that was preposterous. There was no doubt that if I was in that creek, I would have been swept away like a little pebble. The creek rose five to six times its normal size. Most of the time when we had a normal rainy day, the dam would flood and some rocks would fall out of place. No problem, easy fix. But after this devastating rainstorm, the whole layout of the creek shifted. Rocks piled high on each side of the creek, letting a little stream snake right through. All of the rocks I once carried were gone, new ones in place. Trees along the bank washed away, leaving only the ragged roots. The creek was the same, but the appearance was so different.

Rebuilding after that rainstorm triggered some thoughts. I didn't know if I should have been mad or happy, now that I get to build another one. Should I build another one? It's just going to be crushed by another powerful storm anyways. I thought to myself, I truly enjoyed building that dam. I had no purpose or need to build it, yet I still did. Minnows who can't handle the strength of the current reside in my dam, taking shelter, growing there. Even knowing that the boulders I carry, with my now rugged hands, will get washed away at any given rainfall, I still kept building.

My affection towards nature only grew every time I laid a stone over another. After I had finished, I sat down on a nearby log carried from the previous storm and listened to the stream whistling and rushing. I was only going to stay for a short while because I believed that if I stayed too long, this place would soon bore me. But who was I kidding, no two rocks were the same, the flowing water is forever changing, and the life around me is immeasurable, as it is always growing.